Building a backpack game

How the game came together, step by step: what you asked, what I did, and pictures of the in-between steps. 29 October to 1 November 2026.

1 · Setting up

YOU *I'm new to coding. Explain each step in plain words… Build one small step at a time and don't write code until I ask for that step. This game is unrelated to my other project… I have Unreal Engine 5.8 installed, but the game should be small, so a lighter tool may suit it better.*

CLAUDE Made the folder **E:\P4\SmallGame**, started git (no commits), and wrote **CLAUDE.md** with how you like to work. Then asked about the game.

YOU *2D arcade · In a web browser · I take your recommendation · I want to create something like Backpack Hero and Backpack Battles · Automatic + shop*

CLAUDE Recommended plain **HTML + JavaScript**: no installs, just open the page in a browser. The game: our own backpack game, items with shapes on a grid, automatic fights on timers, a shop between rounds.

2 · The first pieces

YOU *yes lets do the first step, just a page that shows the backpack grid*

CLAUDE A 6 × 4 grid of squares in a web page, then, one step at a time: a draggable **Sword**, a **Shield** that can't overlap it, stats on each item, an **automatic fight** against a Goblin on timers, and a **shop** with gold. Each step tested before the next.

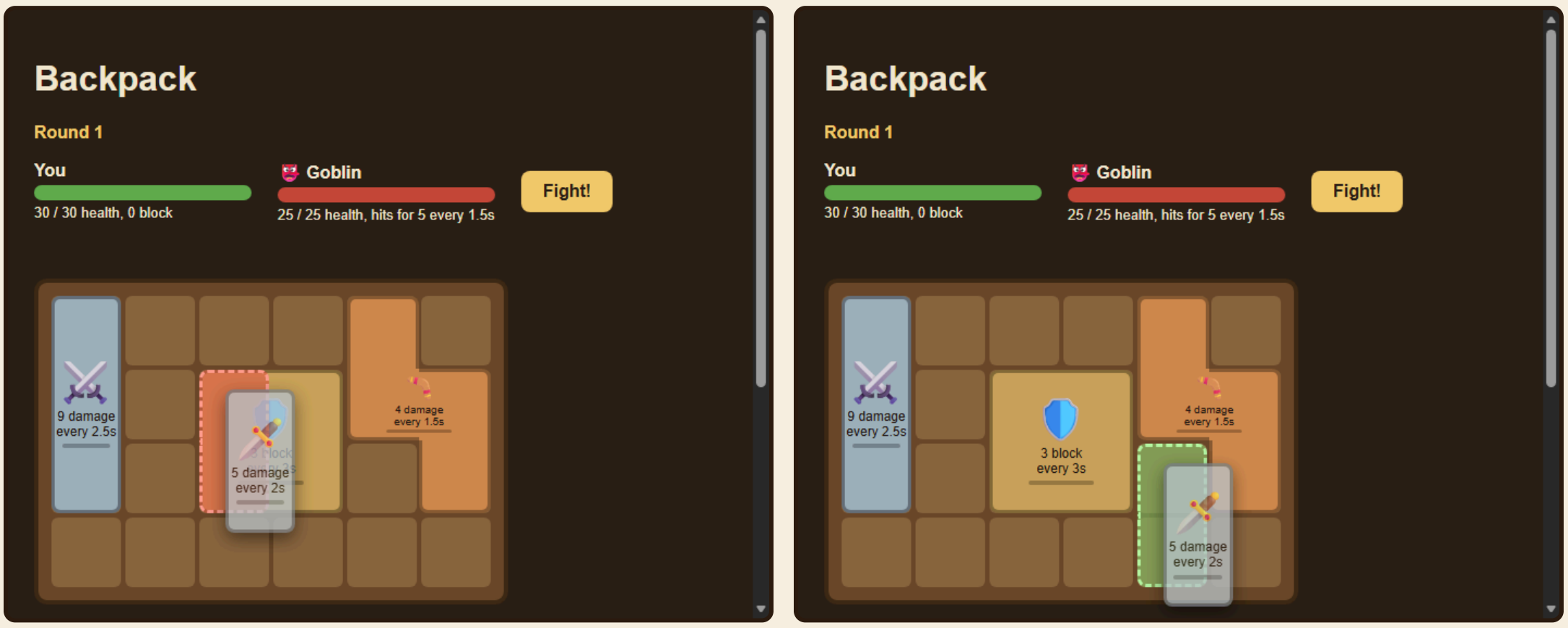
YOU *it seems the herb is breaking the layout of the backpack*

CLAUDE Fixed: every row and column is now exactly one square, so small items can't stretch them.

3 · Bigger items and smoother dragging

YOU *lets try it with something a bit larger, a three row sword and a boomerang that has a more odd shape of three bent rows. also please add it so when dragging, you can go over the other pieces and it just shows a ghost of the grid where you hover...*

CLAUDE Added the **Greatsword** and a bent **Boomerang**. While you drag, a **ghost** shows where the item would land: green if it fits, red if it doesn't.

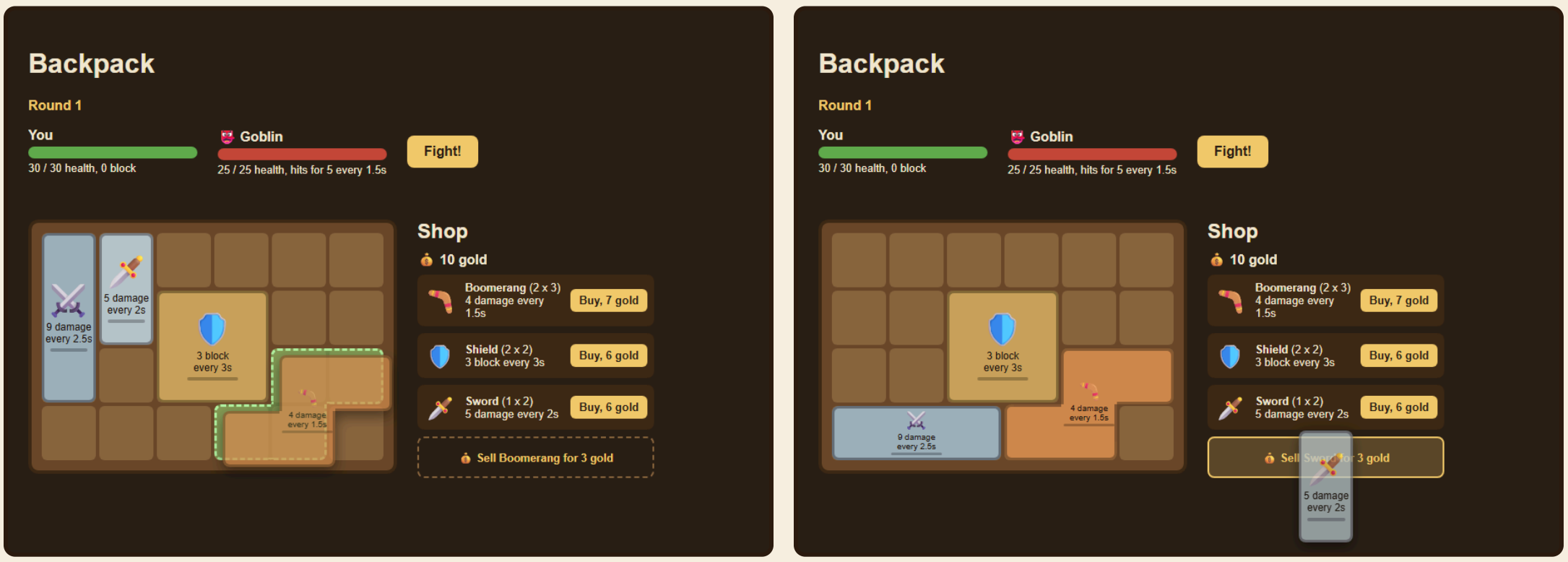


The ghost while dragging the Sword: red over the Shield, green on a free spot.

4 · Selling and rotating

YOU *great, now lets add a sell button and rotate, so I can rotate the boomerang for example. the rotate would be when I have the object picked up, with a right click*

CLAUDE **Right click** (or R) while holding turns an item a quarter turn. A **Sell** spot pays for items dropped on it.

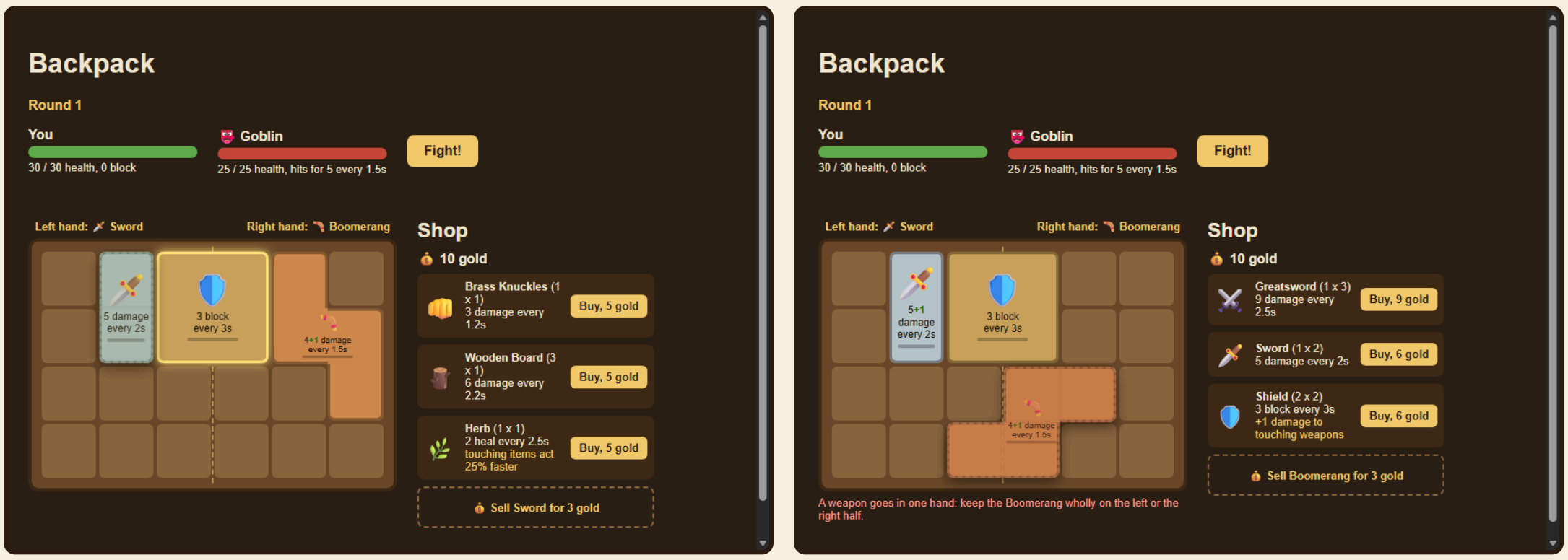


The Boomerang turned while held, and the Sword over the Sell spot.

5 · Placement matters: bonuses, hands, new items

YOU *lets do number 1. lets also introduce some more items, some brass knuckles, a wooden board. a helmet made of paper, a traffic cone… create a rule that only two weapons can be wielded (left and right hand)…*

CLAUDE Items now **boost their neighbours** (the Shield gives touching weapons +1 damage, the Herb makes them faster) and glow while you drag. Six street and backyard items. The backpack is split into a **left and right hand**, one weapon each.

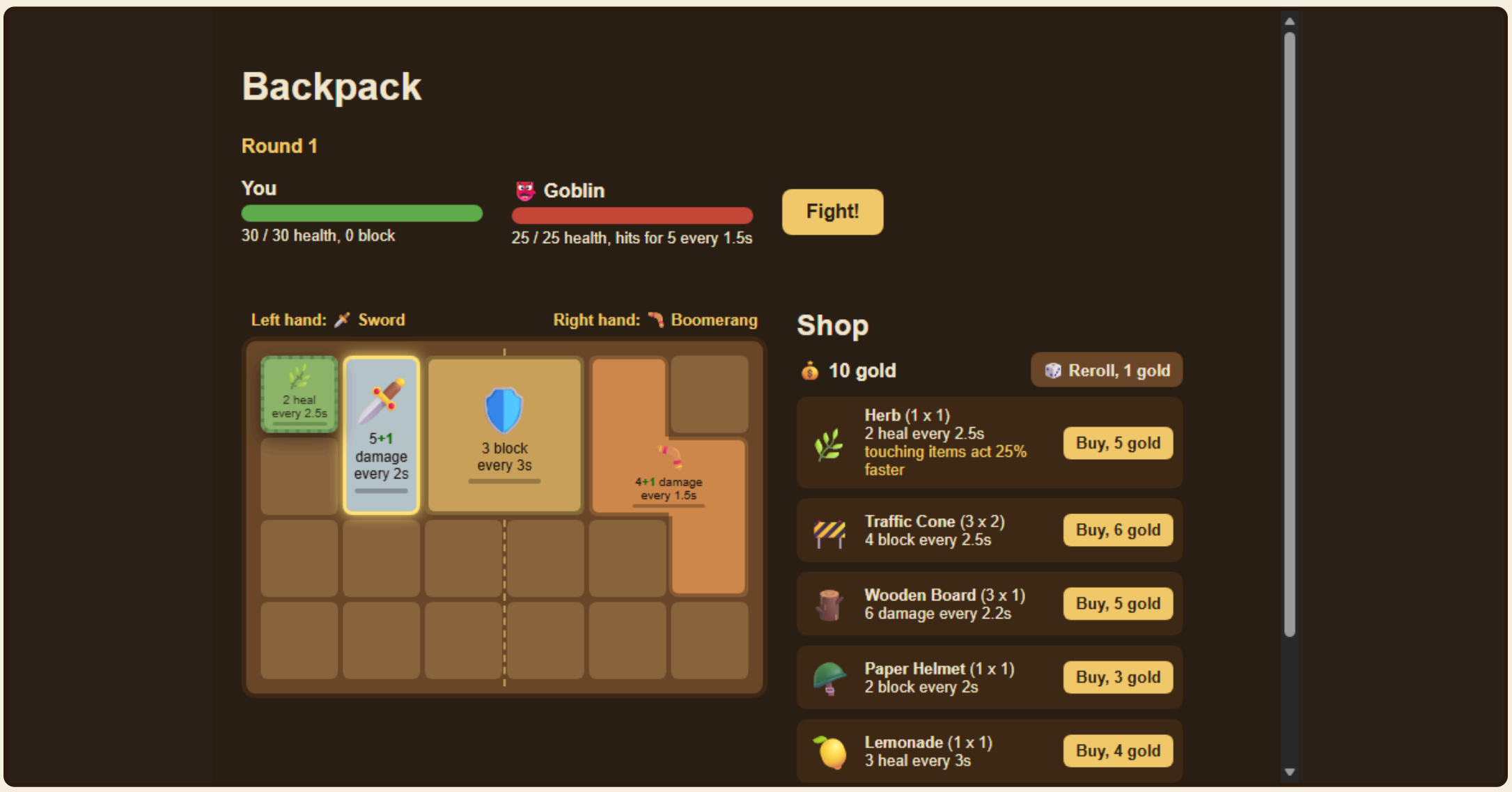


The Shield glows as the Sword comes near; a Boomerang across the middle line is refused.

6 · Buying by dragging

YOU *can you make it so I can just drag and drop from the shop and it counts as buying. also lets do the sell price the same as the buy price… make the shop bigger to 5 items and give it a 'reroll' for 1 gold*

CLAUDE Shop items can be **dragged straight into the backpack** to buy them. Five offers, a 1-gold **Reroll**, and selling pays the full price back for now.

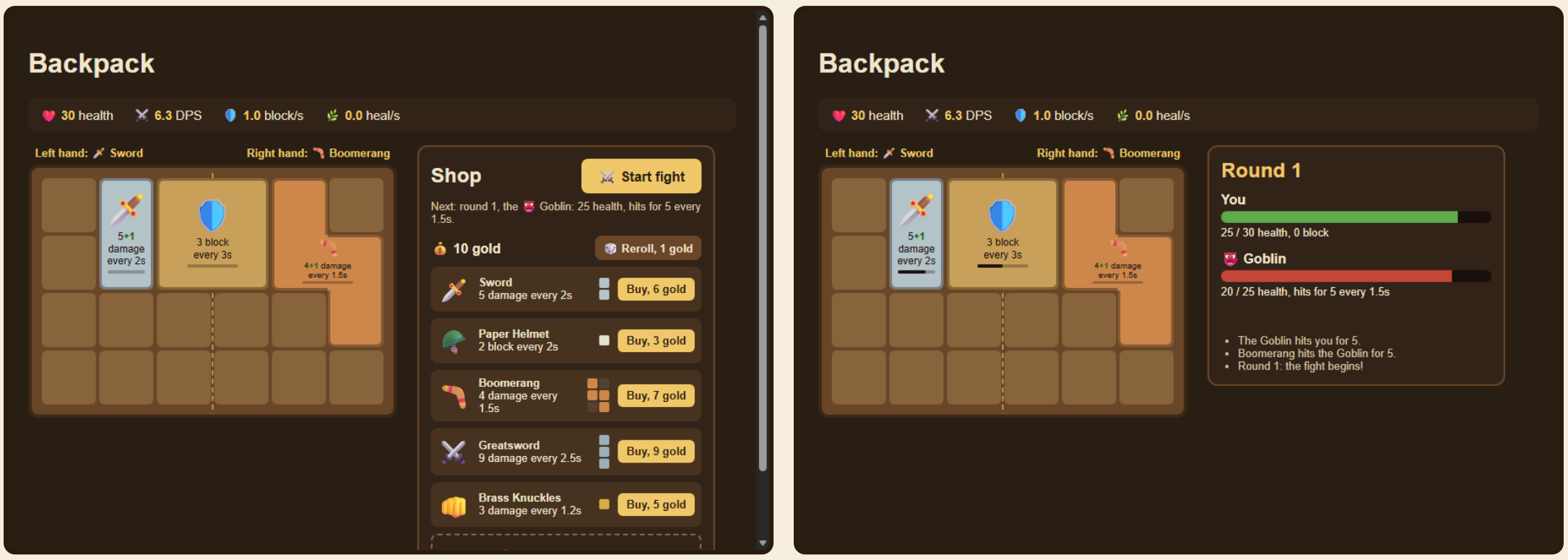


Dragging a Herb out of the shop; the Sword glows because the Herb would speed it up.

7 · Shapes in the shop, a totals strip, separate screens

YOU *display the size of the items in the shop... give a readout of the total DPS and the other stats somewhere on the top... the shop and the fight portion should be separate windows*

CLAUDE Each shop card shows a small drawing of the item's shape. A strip at the top adds up your **damage per second**, block and heal. The shop and the fight became **two screens**.



The shop screen and the fight screen.

8 · Going scavenging

YOU *lets take the start fight and move it to the right. call it go scavenge... areas... from easy to medium to hard. introduce a few enemies and show a comparison to your own strength... preview the rewards...*

CLAUDE **Go scavenge** opens a map with three areas: Backyard (Raccoon), Back Alley (Guard Dog) and Edge of the Woods (Black Bear). A **power score** compares you with each enemy, with a guess like "Should win" and the gold you'd earn.

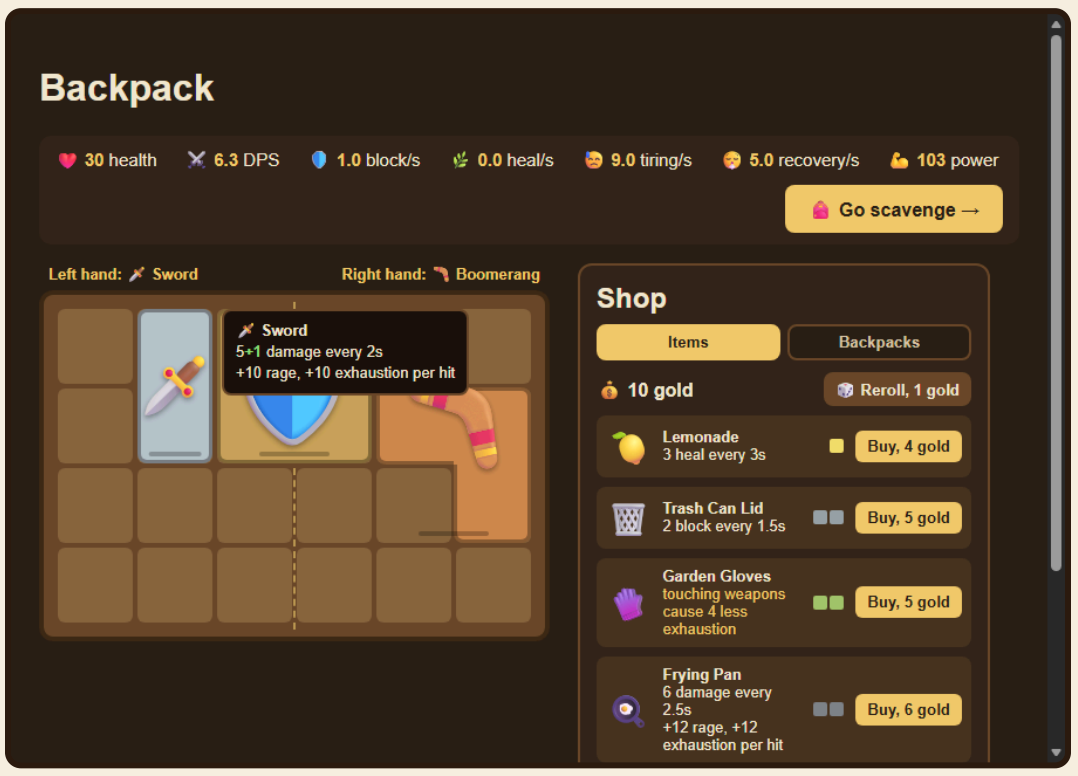


The scavenge screen.

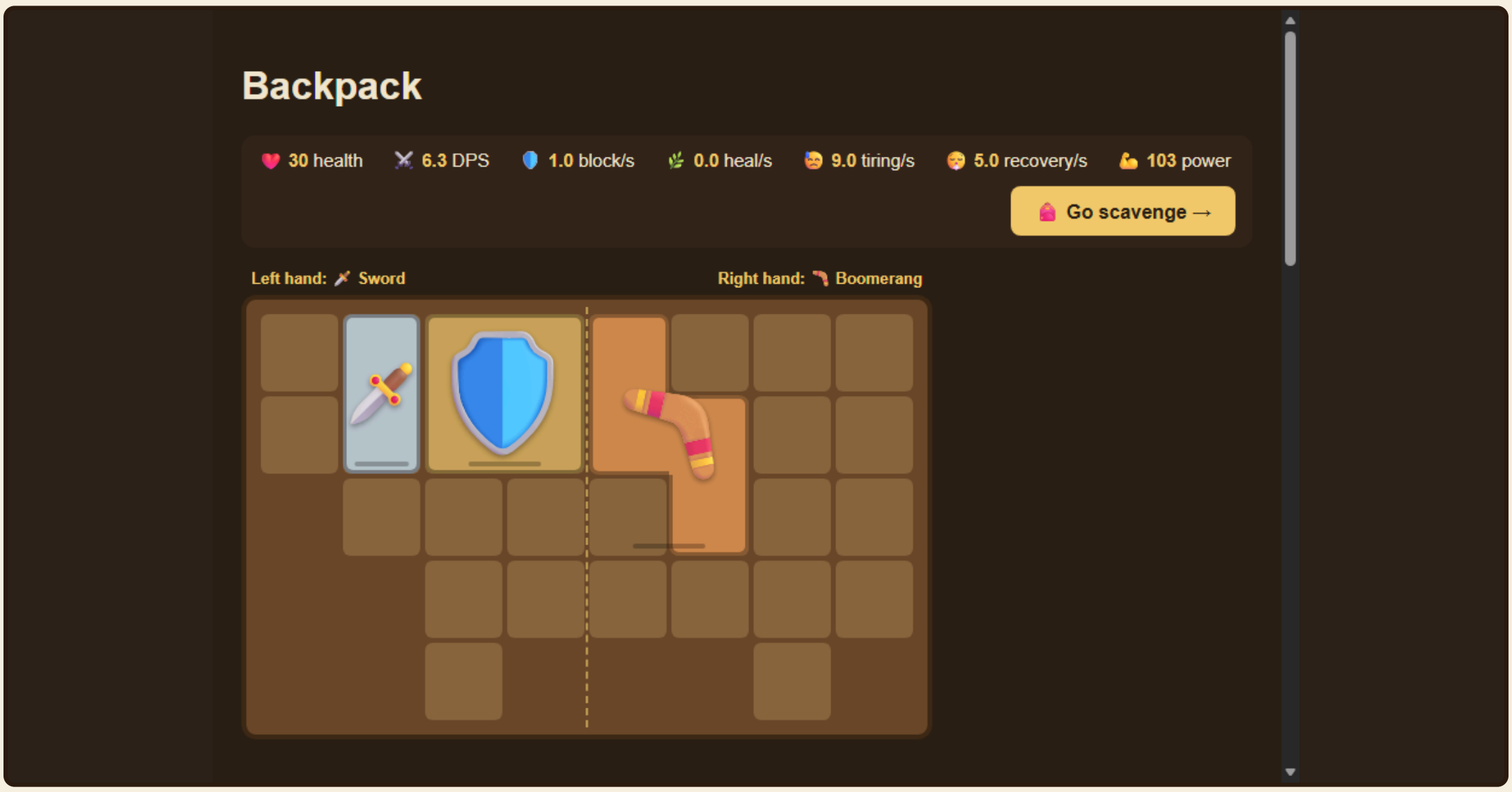
9 · Rage, exhaustion and shaped backpacks

YOU *scale up the images to fill the shapes. no text until you hover over it. make weapons create rage but also cause exhaustion... add 10 more items of varying sizes. have an option to buy bigger backpacks, lets say 10 different ones...*

CLAUDE Pictures fill the items, details show on hover. Weapon hits build **rage** (up to 3× damage) and **exhaustion** (at 100 your weapons stop until you catch your breath). Ten new items and ten **backpacks with uneven shapes**.



Details on hover; a fight with rage and exhaustion maxed out.

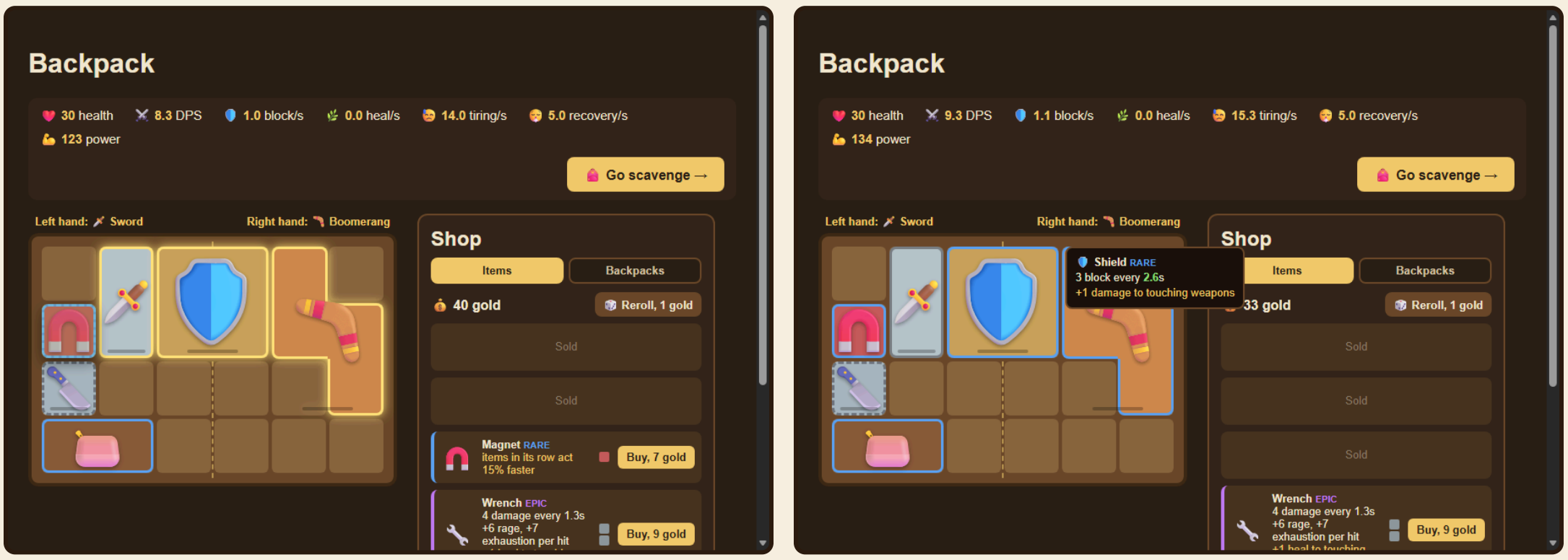


The Shopping Cart backpack with its uneven shape.

10 · Rows, columns, holsters and rarities

YOU *lets introduce more objects and more effects for surrounding bits... all in row, all in a line, above weapon doesnt count to the limit (holster)... introduce different rarities, common, rare, epic... by the way, how did you create the icons?*

CLAUDE Boosts can now reach a whole **row** or **column**. A **Holster** carries a weapon without using a hand. Items are **Common, Rare or Epic** (the Wrench became Epic). The icons so far were emoji, the little pictures you can type.

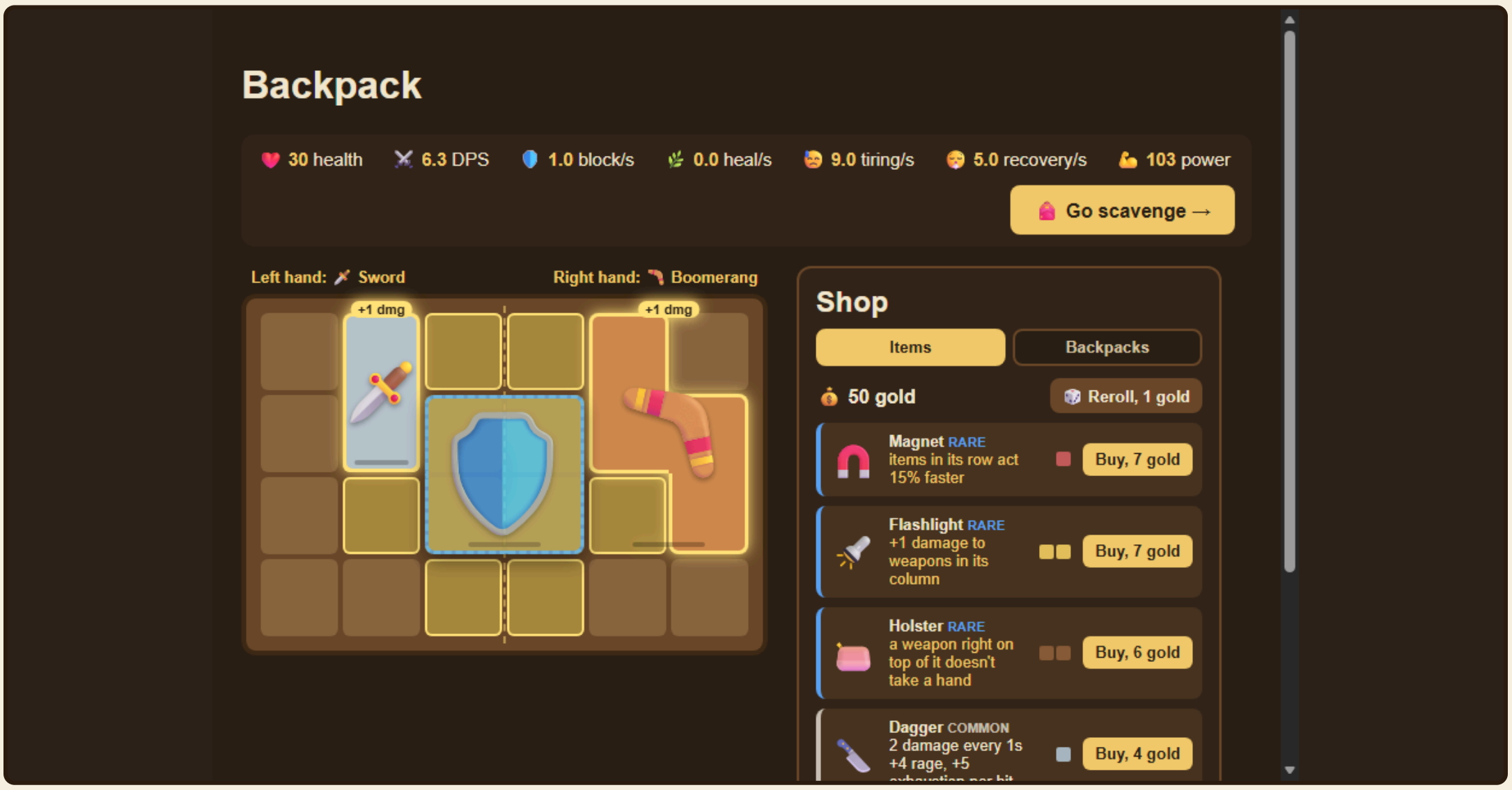


A Magnet speeding up its whole row; rarity colours in the shop.

11 · Seeing the effect before you drop

YOU *when dragging an object, can you mark the effect it has on the surrounding area as a preview? also with a (+1) or so...*

CLAUDE While you drag, the squares an item would reach turn gold, and each affected item gets a badge such as **+1 dmg**.



Holding the Shield: the squares it touches and the +1 dmg badges.

12 · Our own pictures with a local image generator

YOU *lets visually improve it somewhat, can you recommend me a decent free image generator? maybe running it locally as well*

CLAUDE Recommended **ComfyUI** with **FLUX.1 schnell** on your RTX 4070 Super: free, private, and its pictures may be used in a game you sell.

YOU *its downloaded, I dont want to run them all by hand in comfy ui though... can you give me a script I can copy paste or can you run it from here for me?*

CLAUDE Wrote **tools/make_icons.py**: it sends one job per item to ComfyUI, saves the picture, and makes the white background see-through. All 32 items took about five minutes.

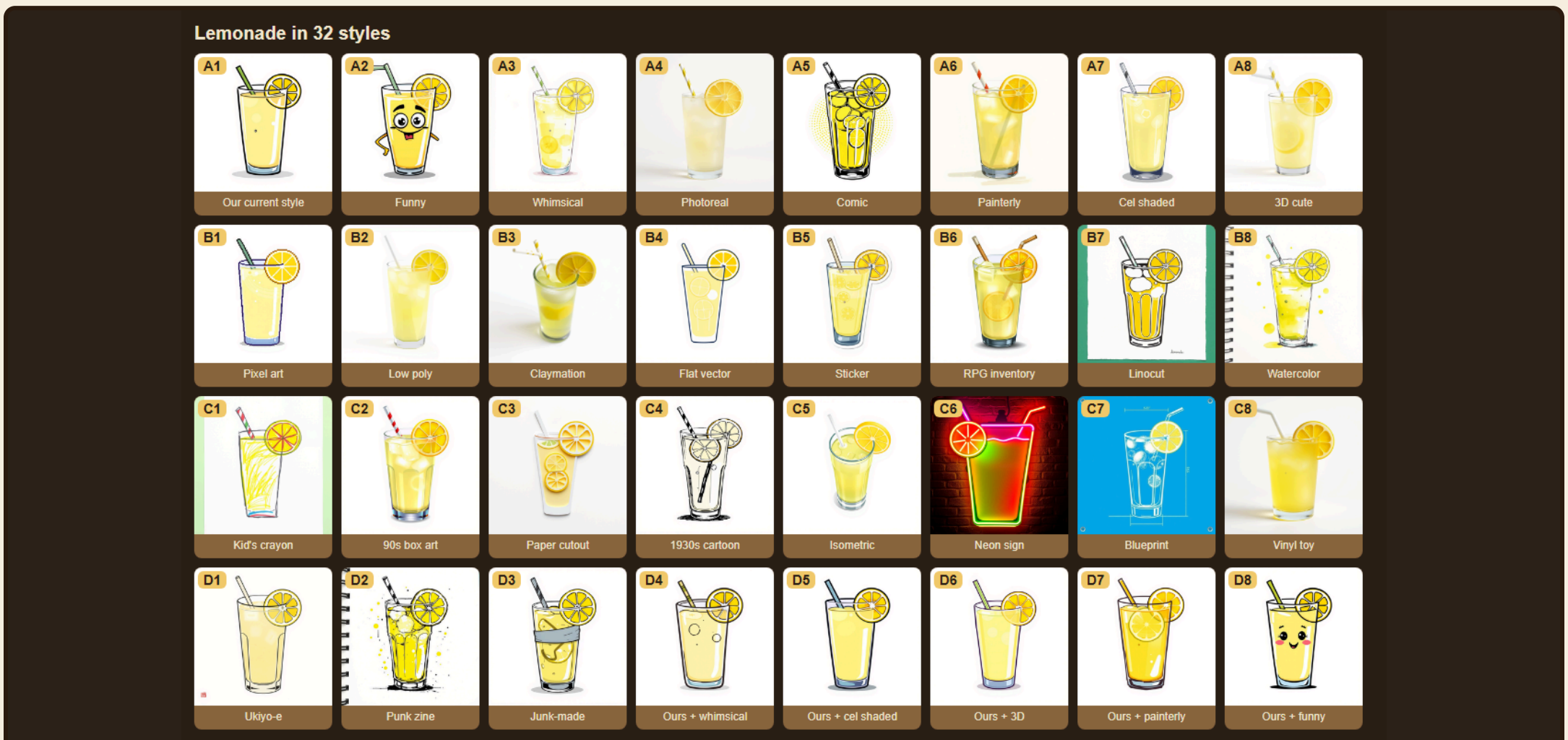


The first set of item pictures, in a cartoon style.

13 · Finding a style

YOU *put them on a lineup please and give them letters and numbers… run a test batch with the boomerang with different style prompts, funny, whimsical, photoreal, comic, painterly, cel shaded, 3d…*

CLAUDE Lineups with labels like **A1**, and the same item drawn in **32 styles**. The Boomerang came out as a straight stick, so we switched to the Lemonade.

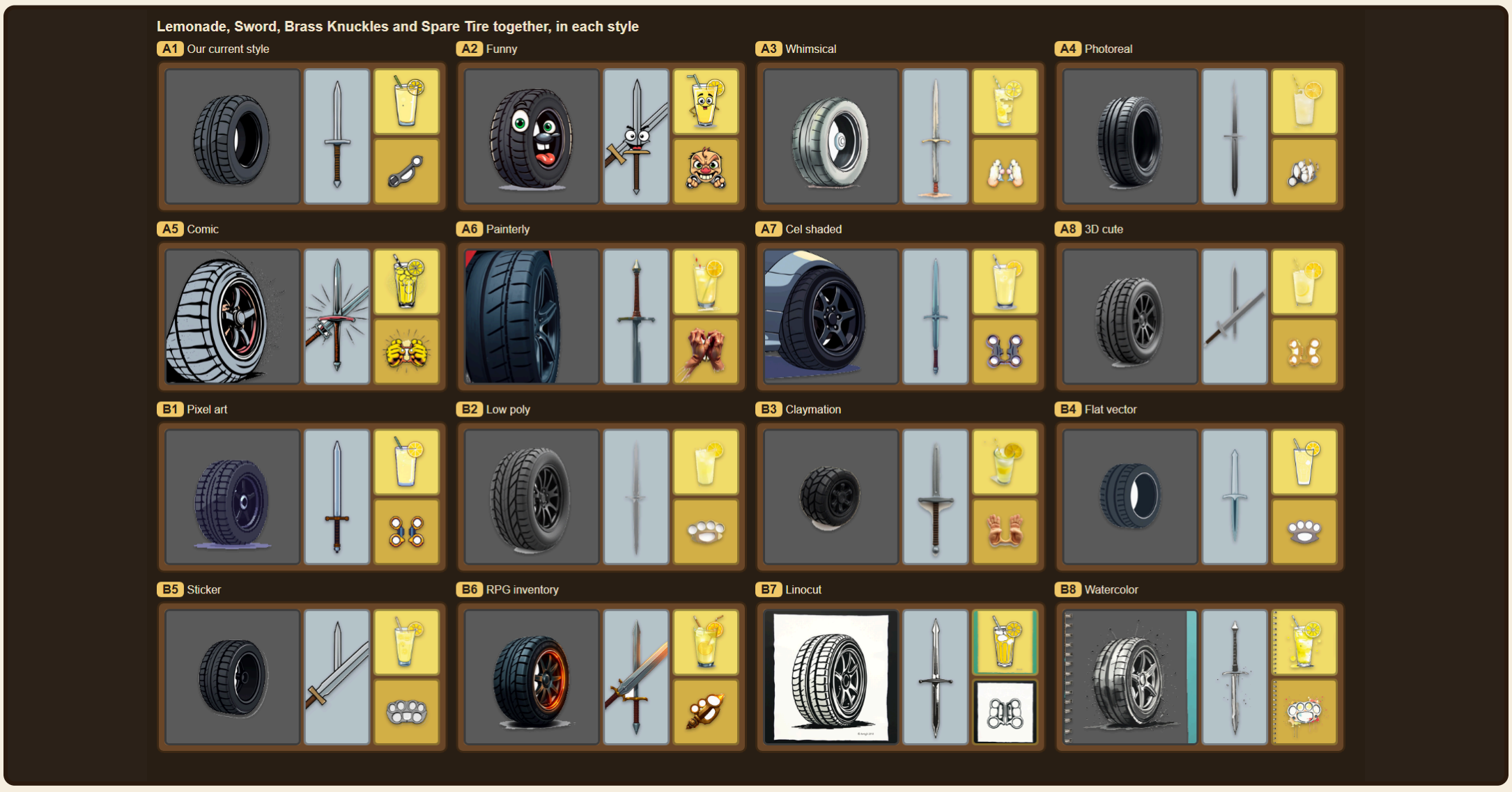


The Lemonade in 32 styles.

14 · Items together in a backpack

YOU *lets run the sword, the brass knuckles and the spare tire with all the variants… put them next to each other in a mock up on the background of the backpack…*

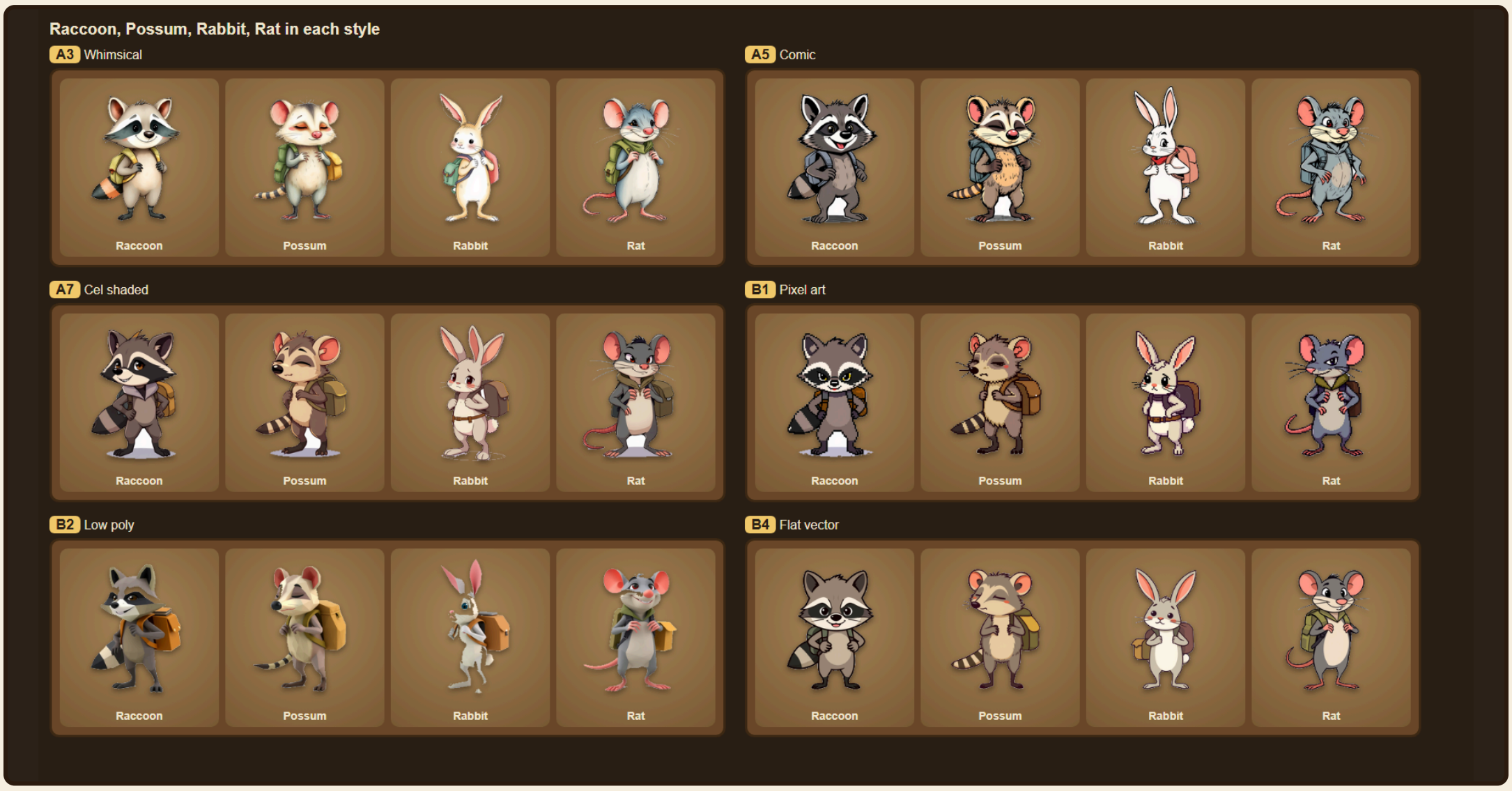
CLAUDE A **mockup** per style with four items together in a small backpack, so the set can be judged as a whole.



Styles A1 to B8 with four items each.

15 · Characters, and mixing styles

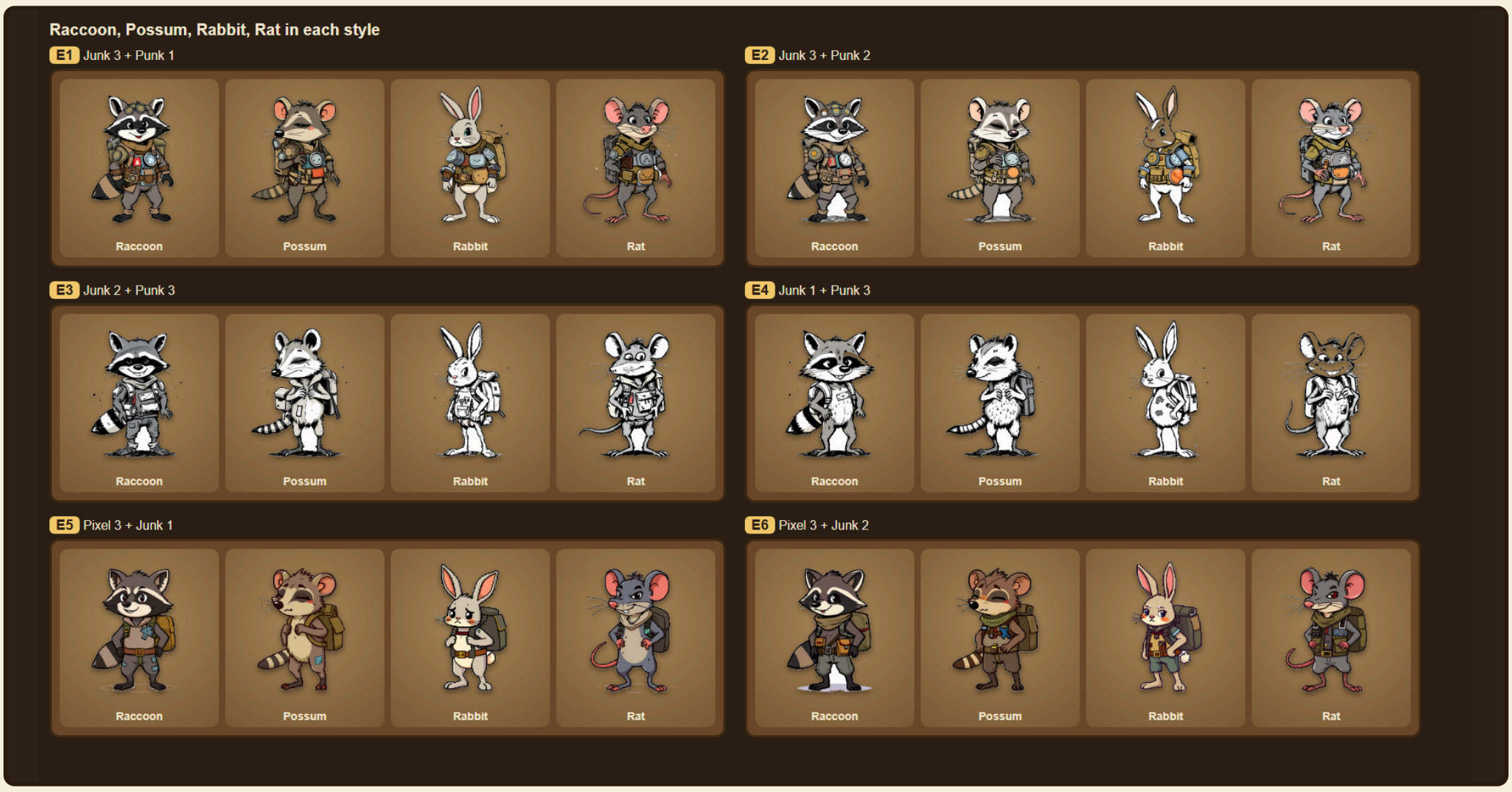
YOU *lets run a raccoon, a possum, a rabbit and a rat, (these should be characters you can choose…) through A3, A5, A7, B1, B2, B4, B6, B7, B8, C4, D3, D2*



Four characters in six of the chosen styles.

YOU *lets run the characters with a mix of b1, d3 and d2 in varying strengths*

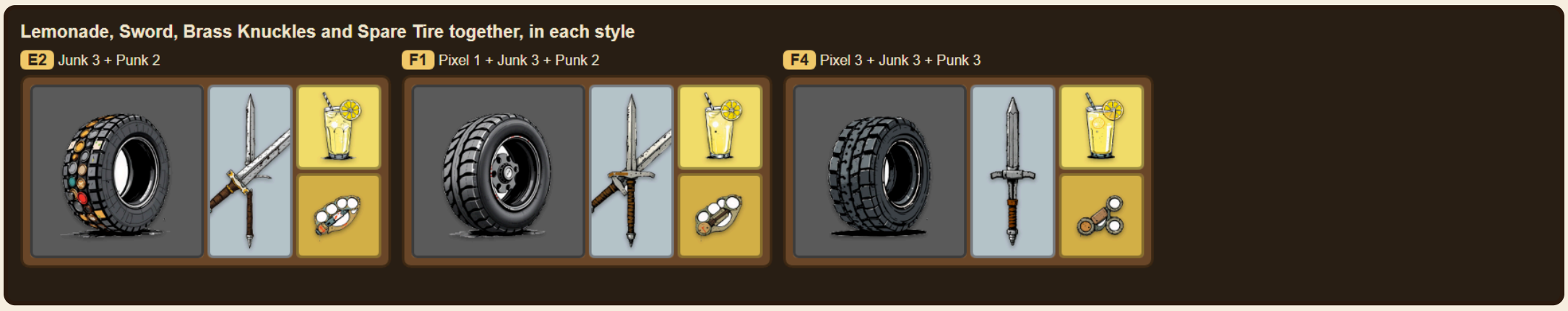
CLAUDE Twelve **mixes** of Pixel art, Junk-made and Punk zine at different strengths, labelled E1 to F4.



The characters in the mixes E1 to E6.

16 · Choosing F1

YOU *lets try E2, f1 and f4 as well please*



The four items in E2, F1 and F4.

YOU *can we go f1 and slap a pixel art effect on top?*

CLAUDE Tried a pixel art effect in two versions. You decided it didn't work, so it was removed, and everything was redrawn in **F1**: all items, the backpacks and the characters.



All 32 items in style F1.

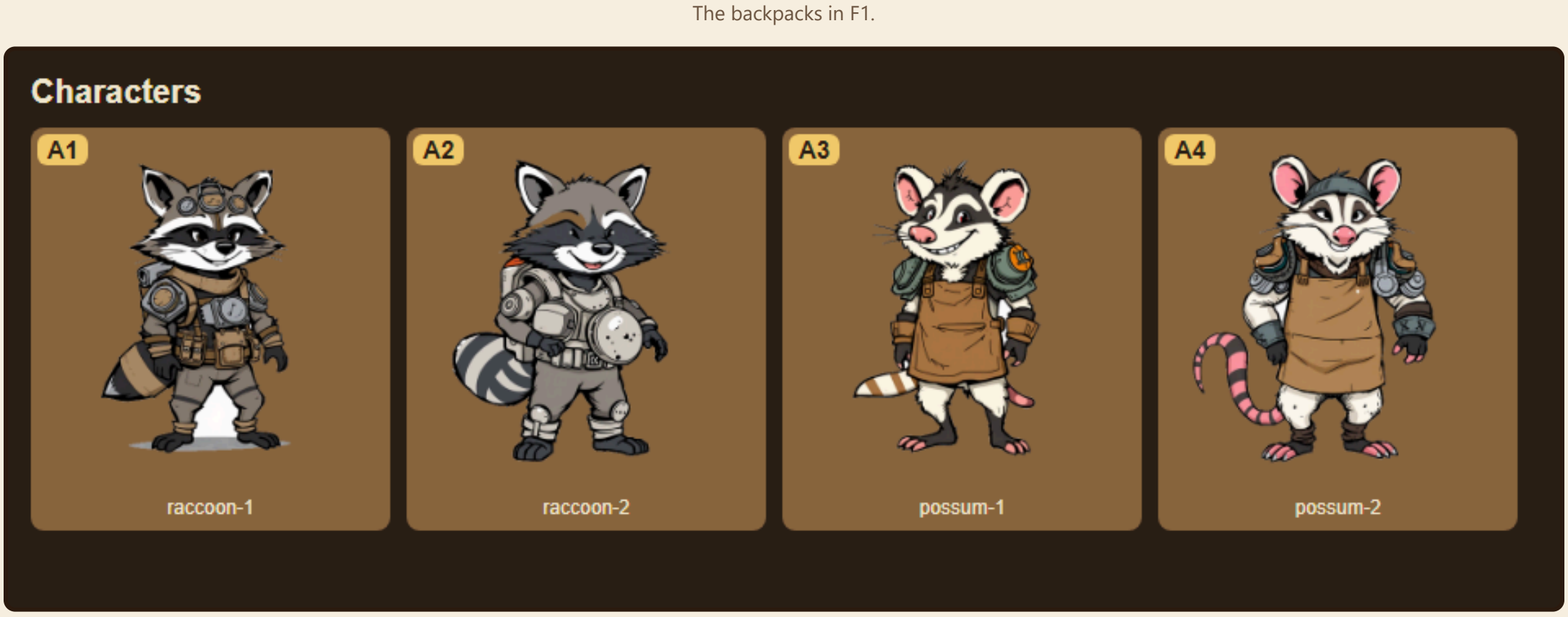
17 · Backpacks and characters in F1

YOU *...lets run f1 with all the items and also other items, for example the backpack outlines, menu buttons etc. for the buttons... wood planks that look handmade... with white painting on top thats peeling off a bit*

CLAUDE Made pictures of every backpack and plank buttons. A board and fabric for the backgrounds were too busy, so you had them removed.



The backpacks in F1.



The raccoon and possum made for the new look.

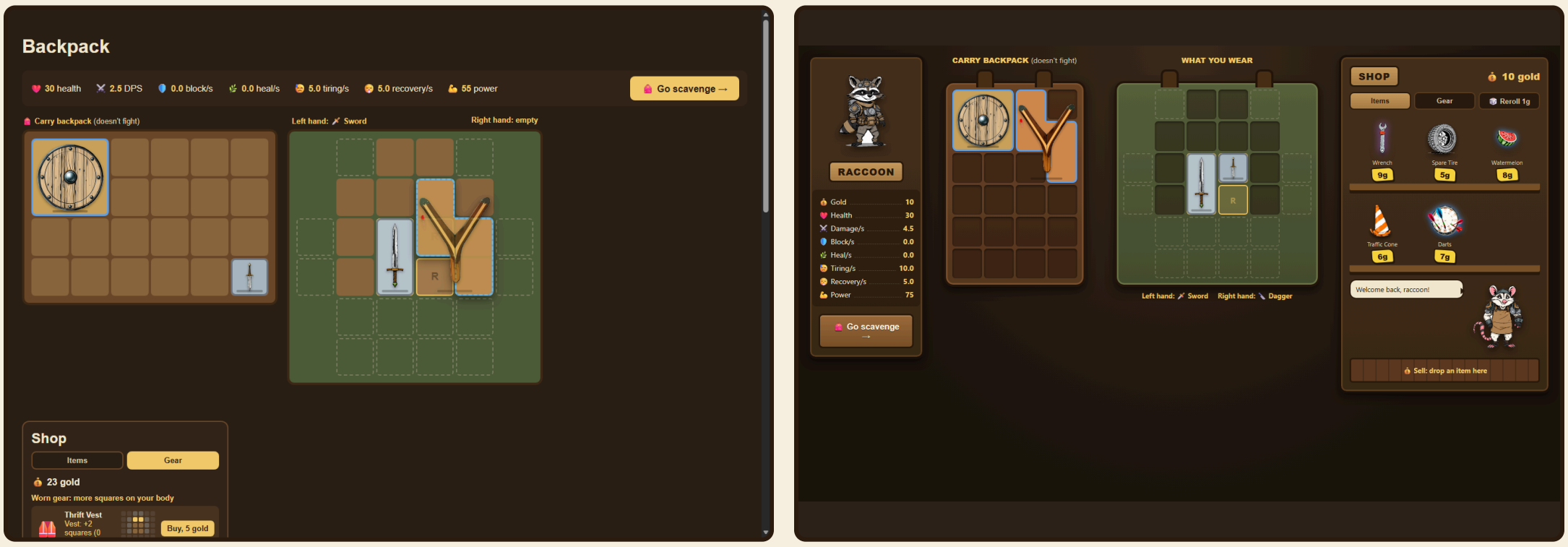
18 · A new look from your concept

YOU *lets rework the look of the game a bit. I have a concept mock up here... on the left side should be all the readouts written like a list... the character in the mock up is far too big... lets put the possum in there... lets split the backpack in two parts...*



Your concept mockup.

CLAUDE **Step 1:** a **carry backpack** that doesn't fight, and what you **wear**: just your two hands at first, with vests, belts and pockets adding squares. **Step 2:** the look from your concept: readouts as a list, the raccoon, leather backpacks, shelves with price tags, and the possum.



Step 1 (a Boomerang going onto the vest, hand and belt) and the game now.